



Difficult Questions for Adaptive Coordination

Appendix: Questions Organized by Which Orientation They Challenge

A companion collection of questions designed to surface the assumptions that each coordination orientation protects.

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Global Governance Frameworks

Appendix: Difficult Questions for Adaptive Coordination

A companion to "Adaptive Coordination: A Protocol for Integrative Decision-Making"

These questions are not weapons. They are invitations — designed to surface the assumptions that each coordination orientation protects, and to open the space for more complete seeing. A well-placed question can shift the entire geometry of a conversation.

Use them sparingly. One or two per meeting is usually enough. The goal is not to interrogate but to create the conditions under which the group can think more clearly than any individual within it.

Questions that challenge tribal loyalty

- "What would we do differently if we had no shared history — if we were deciding this for the first time?"
- "Is our loyalty to each other helping us see clearly, or helping us avoid something?"
- "What are we protecting that no longer needs protection?"

Questions that challenge power and dominance

- "Who in this room is not speaking — and what might they see that the loudest voices don't?"
- "Is the energy behind this proposal coming from conviction or from the need to win?"
- "What would strength look like here if it didn't look like control?"

Questions that challenge rules, authority, and orthodoxy

- "Is the procedure itself the problem?"
- "What if the mandate we're following was designed for a situation that no longer exists?"
- "What does being in service of something larger than any institution — including your own beliefs about what that something is — actually require here?"

A formulation that works across belief systems: *"What are you in service of that you didn't choose and can't fully understand?"* This points at the experience of orientation toward something beyond personal comprehension — accessible to a devout believer, a secular systems thinker, and a contemplative practitioner alike.

Questions that challenge optimization and competition

- "Are we optimizing the right thing — or just the most measurable thing?"
- "What would we do if there were no competitors and no scoreboard?"
- "What second- and third-order effects are we choosing not to look at because they complicate the model?"
- "Why does your country/company/organization matter more than any other?"

That last question exposes whether strategic identity rests on genuine functional differentiation or on tribal loyalty wearing strategic clothing. Its inverse is equally revealing: *"What would the world lose if this organization disappeared — and what would it gain?"*

Questions that challenge consensus and inclusion

- "Is inclusion actually the priority here, or are we using it to avoid a harder choice?"
- "Whose comfort are we protecting by not deciding?"
- "Are we hearing everyone because it serves the outcome, or because not hearing someone would feel like a violation?"
- "What if the most caring thing we can do right now is to act without full agreement?"

Questions that challenge systems thinking

- "Is our map of this system accurate — or just elegant?"
- "What would change our mind?"
- "Are we being systemic, or are we using complexity as a reason not to commit?"
- "What would someone who doesn't think in systems see here that we're missing?"

Questions that challenge holistic sensing

- "Is what we're sensing real, or is it what we want to be emerging?"
- "Are we using 'emergence' as an excuse to avoid the discomfort of choosing?"
- "What is the most grounded, concrete thing we can do right now — regardless of what the field seems to want?"

Meta-questions (challenge the meeting itself)

- "What problem are we *actually* trying to solve?"
- "What happens if we succeed?"
- "Who is not in the room that this decision affects?"
- "Which part of our identity are we protecting by not looking at this?"
- "If this decision failed, how would it fail?"
- "What are we not seeing?"

These questions can be used by facilitators, distributed to participants before a meeting, or drawn from spontaneously when a conversation is circling. They are most powerful when asked with genuine curiosity rather than as rhetorical challenges — the tone is inquiry, not prosecution.